

# A Triumph of Surgery

Class 10 CBSE • Footprints Without Feet • James Herriot

## Detailed Exam-Oriented Solutions

Includes complete NCERT exercise solutions, character sketches, important vocabulary, quotations, extract-based questions, very-short/short/long answers, value-based questions, additional questions, CBSE-style questions and MCQs.

Note: The NCERT exercise structure has been checked against the current NCERT-linked chapter material. The chapter contains Read and Find Out, Think About It and Talk About It activities.

## 1. Chapter Information

|                 |                                                                 |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Title           | A Triumph of Surgery                                            |
| Author          | James Herriot                                                   |
| Book            | Footprints Without Feet – Class 10 English Supplementary Reader |
| Type            | Short story / prose                                             |
| Narrator        | James Herriot, a veterinary surgeon                             |
| Main Characters | Tricki, Mrs Pumphrey, Dr Herriot                                |

## 2. Character Sketches

### Tricki

Tricki is a small, pampered dog whose serious condition is caused mainly by overeating and lack of exercise. He is greedy and has become extremely fat and inactive. At Herriot's surgery, a controlled diet, water, exercise and the company of other dogs quickly restore his health. He is playful, energetic and happy when he is allowed to live a more natural routine.

### Mrs Pumphrey

Mrs Pumphrey is a wealthy, affectionate and highly indulgent pet owner. She genuinely loves Tricki, but her excessive affection becomes harmful because she keeps feeding him rich food and cannot refuse his demands. She is emotional and easily worried, yet she trusts Herriot's judgement. Her mistake is not lack of love but lack of moderation and practical understanding.

### Dr James Herriot

Dr Herriot is a practical, observant, experienced and tactful veterinary surgeon. He immediately identifies overfeeding and lack of exercise as the real problem. Instead of unnecessary medicine or surgery, he uses controlled food, water, exercise and social interaction. He also understands Mrs Pumphrey's emotional nature and handles her sensitively.

## 3. Important Words & Meanings

|                     |                                                              |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>bloated</b>      | swollen or excessively enlarged                              |
| <b>rheumy</b>       | having watery discharge from the eyes or nose                |
| <b>listless</b>     | lacking energy or enthusiasm                                 |
| <b>malnutrition</b> | poor health caused by an inadequate or improper diet         |
| <b>relent</b>       | to become less strict or severe                              |
| <b>lumbago</b>      | pain in the lower part of the back                           |
| <b>regime</b>       | a prescribed system or course of diet and exercise           |
| <b>distraught</b>   | extremely worried or upset                                   |
| <b>surgery</b>      | a place where a doctor or veterinary surgeon treats patients |
| <b>scrimmage</b>    | a rough or confused struggle                                 |
| <b>convalescing</b> | recovering from an illness                                   |
| <b>lithe</b>        | flexible and graceful in movement                            |
| <b>suffering</b>    | experiencing pain or illness                                 |
| <b>indulgent</b>    | too willing to allow or satisfy someone's wishes             |
| <b>tempted</b>      | strongly attracted to do something                           |

## 4. Important Quotations / Lines

“I can’t bear to refuse him.”

Significance: This reveals Mrs Pumphrey’s excessive affection. Her inability to refuse Tricki’s demands becomes the main reason for his unhealthy lifestyle.

“Tricki’s only fault was greed.”

Significance: This identifies the immediate behavioural problem: Tricki loves food and never refuses it.

“You must harden your heart and keep him on a very strict diet.”

Significance: Herriot tells Mrs Pumphrey that genuine care requires discipline, not unlimited feeding.

“He had never been known to refuse food.”

Significance: This shows Tricki’s greed and explains how he became seriously overweight.

“A triumph of surgery.”

Significance: Mrs Pumphrey uses this phrase to praise Herriot’s treatment, although no surgery was actually performed. The title is therefore humorous and ironic.

## 5. Complete NCERT Textbook Solutions

### A. Read and Find Out — Page 1

#### Q. Why is Mrs Pumphrey worried about Tricki?

Answer: Mrs Pumphrey is worried because Tricki has become extremely fat, weak and listless. He has no energy, looks unhealthy, and later develops symptoms such as vomiting and loss of

appetite. She mistakenly believes that he is suffering from malnutrition.

**Q. What does she do to help him? Is she wise in this?**

Answer: She tries to make Tricki stronger by giving him extra food between meals, including malt, cod-liver oil and Horlicks. She also gives him rich foods such as cream cakes and chocolates. She is not wise because overfeeding and lack of exercise are actually causing his problem.

**Q. Who does 'I' refer to in this story?**

Answer: 'I' refers to James Herriot, the narrator and veterinary surgeon who treats Tricki.

## **B. Read and Find Out — Page 3**

**Q. Is the narrator as rich as Tricki's mistress?**

Answer: No. The narrator is not as rich as Mrs Pumphrey. Her wealthy lifestyle is suggested by the luxurious care given to Tricki and by the large amount of rich food and other comforts available in her household.

**Q. How does he treat the dog?**

Answer: Herriot takes Tricki to his surgery and initially gives him no food for two days, but provides plenty of water. He then introduces food gradually and lets Tricki mix and play with the other dogs. Regular activity and a controlled diet restore his health.

**Q. Why is he tempted to keep Tricki on as a permanent guest?**

Answer: Herriot is tempted because Mrs Pumphrey keeps sending luxurious food and drink for Tricki—eggs, wine and brandy. Herriot and his colleagues enjoy these provisions, making Tricki's stay unexpectedly pleasant for them.

**Q. Why does Mrs Pumphrey think the dog's recovery is 'a triumph of surgery'?**

Answer: Mrs Pumphrey believes that Tricki has been saved by Herriot's professional treatment and surgical skill. She is so grateful that she calls the recovery a 'triumph of surgery', although no operation was performed. The expression creates humour and irony.

## **C. Think About It**

**Q. What kind of a person do you think the narrator, a veterinary surgeon, is? Would you say he is tactful as well as full of common sense?**

Answer: Herriot is observant, practical, compassionate and experienced. He quickly understands that Tricki's real problem is overfeeding and lack of exercise. He avoids unnecessary medication or surgery and cures the dog through a sensible routine. He is also tactful because he understands Mrs Pumphrey's emotional attachment and communicates with her in a way that makes her accept his advice.

**Q. Do you think Tricki was happy to go home? What do you think will happen now?**

Answer: Yes, Tricki is clearly delighted when he sees Mrs Pumphrey and jumps into her lap. However, his long-term health will depend on whether Mrs Pumphrey changes her habits. If she again overfeeds him and prevents him from exercising, Tricki may become unhealthy once more.

**Q. Do you think this is a real-life episode, or mere fiction? Or is it a mixture of both?**

Answer: It can be read as a mixture of real-life experience and literary storytelling. James Herriot was a veterinary surgeon, so the episode reflects the kind of experiences he encountered in veterinary practice. At the same time, the exaggerated situations, humour and Mrs Pumphrey's reactions give the story a fictional and entertaining quality.

## **D. Talk About It — Suggested Model Answers**

**Q. This episode describes the silly behaviour of a rich woman who is foolishly indulgent, perhaps because she is lonely. Do you think such people are merely silly, or can their actions cause harm to others?**

Answer: Such behaviour can cause real harm. Excessive affection without discipline can damage the health, habits and independence of the person or animal being cared for. Mrs Pumphrey's overindulgence makes Tricki seriously unhealthy. Good care requires affection as well as responsibility and moderation.

**Q. Do you think there are also parents like Mrs Pumphrey?**

Answer: Yes. Some parents may overindulge their children by fulfilling every demand, providing excessive comforts or avoiding discipline. Although their intention may be love, such behaviour can prevent children from developing healthy habits, self-control and independence.

**Q. What would you have done if you were: (i) a member of the staff in Mrs Pumphrey's household, (ii) a neighbour? What would your life have been like, in general?**

Answer: (i) As a staff member, I would respectfully advise Mrs Pumphrey to follow the veterinary surgeon's instructions and reduce Tricki's food. I would also encourage regular exercise. (ii) As a neighbour, I would politely suggest that Tricki needs a healthier routine. Life around such a household would probably involve frequent concern about Tricki because Mrs Pumphrey is extremely emotional about him.

**Q. What would you have done if you were in the narrator's place?**

Answer: I would also focus on the actual cause of Tricki's condition instead of using unnecessary treatment. I would place him on a controlled diet, ensure adequate water and exercise, and allow healthy interaction with other dogs. I would also explain firmly but politely to Mrs Pumphrey that excessive feeding is harmful.

## 6. Extract-Based Questions

“He was so listless, Mr Herriot. He seemed to have no energy. I thought he must be suffering from malnutrition...”

### 1. Who is the speaker?

Answer: Mrs Pumphrey.

### 2. Why does the speaker think Tricki is suffering from malnutrition?

Answer: She mistakenly interprets Tricki’s weakness and lack of energy as a sign of insufficient nourishment.

### 3. What is actually responsible for Tricki’s poor condition?

Answer: Overfeeding, rich food and lack of adequate exercise are the main causes.

### 4. What does this reveal about the speaker?

Answer: She is loving and concerned, but lacks practical understanding of proper pet care.

“Tricki’s only fault was greed. He had never been known to refuse food...”

### 1. What is Tricki’s ‘fault’?

Answer: His greed for food.

### 2. What does the statement tell us about his habits?

Answer: He readily accepts food at almost any time.

### 3. How does this habit affect his health?

Answer: It contributes to excessive weight and poor health.

### 4. Who is largely responsible for enabling this habit?

Answer: Mrs Pumphrey, because she repeatedly gives him rich food and cannot refuse his demands.

“You must harden your heart and keep him on a very strict diet.”

### 1. Who says this?

Answer: Dr Herriot.

### 2. Why must the listener ‘harden’ her heart?

Answer: Mrs Pumphrey must stop giving Tricki whatever food he wants.

### 3. What does ‘strict diet’ mean here?

Answer: It means controlled, appropriate food rather than rich extras and excessive meals.

### 4. Why is this advice important?

Answer: It addresses the actual cause of Tricki’s condition and prevents further deterioration.

“A triumph of surgery.”

### 1. Who says these words?

Answer: Mrs Pumphrey.

### 2. What does the speaker mean?

Answer: She believes Herriot’s professional treatment has produced an extraordinary recovery.

### 3. Was any surgery actually performed?

Answer: No.

### 4. Why is the title humorous?

Answer: The dog recovers through diet, exercise and social activity, not through an operation.

## 7. Very Short Answer Questions

**Q. Who is Tricki?**

Answer: A pampered pet dog owned by Mrs Pumphrey.

**Q. Who is James Herriot?**

Answer: He is the narrator and a veterinary surgeon.

**Q. Why does Tricki become fat?**

Answer: Because of excessive feeding and insufficient exercise.

**Q. What does Mrs Pumphrey give Tricki between meals?**

Answer: Rich extras such as malt, cod-liver oil, Horlicks, cream cakes and chocolates.

**Q. What does Herriot initially give Tricki at the surgery?**

Answer: Plenty of water but no food for the first two days.

**Q. How does Tricki regain his energy?**

Answer: Through controlled food, exercise and interaction with other dogs.

**Q. Why does Mrs Pumphrey send eggs, wine and brandy?**

Answer: She sends them as nourishing supplies for Tricki during his recovery.

**Q. What does Tricki do when he sees his mistress?**

Answer: He leaps into her lap and shows great excitement.

**Q. Was Tricki operated upon?**

Answer: No.

**Q. Why is the title ironic?**

Answer: The recovery is called a triumph of surgery even though no surgery was performed.

## 8. Short Answer Questions

**Q. How did Mrs Pumphrey's love become harmful to Tricki?**

Answer: Mrs Pumphrey loved Tricki deeply but expressed her affection through excessive feeding and constant pampering. She gave him rich food, extras between meals and little exercise. As a result, Tricki became extremely fat, inactive and unhealthy. Her affection was genuine, but her lack of moderation harmed him.

**Q. Why did Herriot decide that Tricki needed to be hospitalised?**

Answer: Herriot realised that Tricki's condition was mainly caused by overfeeding and lack of exercise. He knew that Mrs Pumphrey would find it difficult to control his diet at home because she could not refuse him food. Hospitalisation would remove him from this temptation and allow Herriot to impose a disciplined routine.

**Q. What role did the other dogs play in Tricki's recovery?**

Answer: The other dogs provided Tricki with companionship and encouraged him to move and play. Their presence gave him a natural, active environment. He gradually joined their activities, which helped him regain energy and lose excess weight.

**Q. Why was no medicine needed for Tricki?**

Answer: Tricki's problem was not a serious disease requiring medication. His poor condition resulted from overfeeding and lack of exercise. Once Herriot controlled his food and encouraged activity, his health improved naturally.

**Q. Why did Mrs Pumphrey consider Tricki's recovery extraordinary?**

Answer: She had been extremely worried about Tricki and believed he was seriously ill. When she saw him energetic and healthy again, she was overwhelmed with gratitude. Since she did not understand that diet and exercise were responsible, she attributed the success to Herriot's professional treatment and called it a 'triumph of surgery'.

**Q. How does the story show that moderation is important in caring for pets?**

Answer: The story shows that excessive food and comfort can be harmful even when offered with love. Tricki becomes ill because Mrs Pumphrey gives him too much rich food and too little exercise. His recovery begins only when his diet and routine become controlled. Responsible care therefore requires moderation, discipline and attention to actual needs.

## **9. Long Answer Questions**

**Q. Describe the relationship between Mrs Pumphrey and Tricki.**

Answer: Mrs Pumphrey is deeply attached to Tricki and treats him almost like a member of her family. She is affectionate, protective and constantly worried about his comfort. However, her love becomes excessive. She gives him rich food, snacks and special treats and finds it difficult to refuse his demands. She also misunderstands his obesity as a sign of weakness and attempts to strengthen him by giving him even more food. Tricki's poor health is therefore closely connected with her indulgence. At the same time, Tricki clearly loves his mistress and is delighted when she comes to take him home. Their relationship is loving but unhealthy because affection is not balanced with discipline.

**Q. How did Dr Herriot cure Tricki without using medicines or surgery?**

Answer: Dr Herriot first understood that Tricki's condition was caused mainly by overeating and lack of exercise. He therefore removed Tricki from Mrs Pumphrey's home and brought him to the surgery. For the first two days, he gave him plenty of water but no food. As Tricki became more active, he introduced food gradually. He also allowed him to mix with the other dogs, whose activity encouraged him to run, play and exercise. This simple routine helped Tricki lose his excess weight and regain his energy. Herriot's treatment demonstrates his practical judgement: he solved the real problem instead of treating imaginary illness.

**Q. Why is the title 'A Triumph of Surgery' humorous and ironic?**

Answer: The title is humorous because Mrs Pumphrey calls Tricki's recovery 'a triumph of surgery', but no surgery is actually performed. Herriot does not operate on Tricki or use complicated medical procedures. He simply controls his diet, gives him water and allows him to exercise and socialise with other dogs. Mrs Pumphrey is so impressed by the transformation that she assumes it must be the result of extraordinary medical skill. The title therefore creates irony: the apparent 'surgical triumph' is actually a triumph of common sense, discipline and proper care.

**Q. What qualities of Dr Herriot make him an effective veterinary surgeon?**

Answer: Dr Herriot is observant, practical, knowledgeable, compassionate and tactful. He quickly identifies the real cause of Tricki's condition. Instead of blindly following Mrs Pumphrey's belief that Tricki is malnourished, he recognises the effects of overfeeding. He chooses a simple and effective treatment based on diet, water and exercise. He is also tactful because he understands Mrs Pumphrey's emotional attachment and manages to convince her to leave Tricki with him. His treatment shows that good professional care requires both knowledge and common sense.

## 10. Value-Based Questions

### Q. What lesson does the story teach about love and responsibility?

Answer: Love should be guided by responsibility. Giving unlimited comforts may feel loving, but it can become harmful. Responsible care means understanding real needs and setting healthy limits.

### Q. What can parents learn from Mrs Pumphrey's behaviour?

Answer: Parents can learn that fulfilling every demand is not always beneficial. Children need affection, but they also need discipline, healthy habits, boundaries and opportunities to become independent.

### Q. Why is common sense important in problem-solving?

Answer: Herriot does not complicate Tricki's treatment. He identifies the simple cause and applies a practical solution. The story shows that effective problem-solving often begins with understanding the real cause rather than assuming that a complicated solution is required.

## 11. Additional Important Questions

### Q. Why did Tricki lose interest in food initially?

Answer: His unhealthy condition had progressed to the point where he became inactive and lost his appetite. This alarmed Mrs Pumphrey, who incorrectly interpreted it as evidence that he needed more nourishment.

### Q. Why was Herriot doubtful about the things Mrs Pumphrey had not mentioned?

Answer: Her explanation focused on malnutrition and extra nourishment, but Herriot could see that Tricki was grossly overweight. He therefore suspected that she had not fully described the quantity and richness of the food she was giving him.

### Q. What changed Tricki's lifestyle at the surgery?

Answer: At the surgery, he no longer had unlimited access to rich food. He had controlled meals, plenty of water, exercise and the company of other dogs. This completely changed his routine.

### Q. How does humour make the story enjoyable?

Answer: The story uses exaggeration, Mrs Pumphrey's dramatic reactions, the luxurious food sent for Tricki, and the misunderstanding about 'surgery' to create humour. These elements make the lesson about responsible care entertaining rather than preachy.

### Q. Why can Mrs Pumphrey's behaviour be called overindulgence?

Answer: She gives Tricki more food and comfort than he needs and repeatedly gives in to his demands. Her inability to refuse him makes her affection excessive and unhealthy.

## 12. CBSE Exam-Oriented Questions

### Q. Competency-based: A pet owner notices that her dog is overweight but believes the dog needs more food because it appears weak. What should she do? Give two reasons.

Answer: She should consult a qualified veterinary surgeon and follow a balanced diet-and-exercise plan rather than increasing food on her own. First, weakness and obesity can have different causes and should be assessed professionally. Second, excessive food without adequate exercise can worsen the animal's health, as shown by Tricki.

### Q. Inference-based: Why is Mrs Pumphrey's statement about malnutrition ironic?



Answer: It is ironic because she believes Tricki needs more nourishment, while the actual problem is excessive nourishment. Her attempt to solve the problem by adding food makes the condition worse.

**Q. Analytical: 'The story is not against love; it is against blind indulgence.' Explain.**

Answer: Mrs Pumphrey's love for Tricki is genuine and affectionate. The problem is that she expresses love by giving him whatever he wants, even when it is harmful. Herriot's treatment also shows care, but his care includes discipline, limits and healthy habits. Thus the story distinguishes responsible love from blind indulgence.

**Q. Case-based: Tricki becomes active after interacting with other dogs. What does this suggest about environment and behaviour?**

Answer: A healthy environment can strongly influence behaviour. At home Tricki is inactive and overfed, while at the surgery he is surrounded by active dogs and a disciplined routine. Their presence stimulates him to move, play and become energetic again.

## 13. MCQs

1. Mrs Pumphrey is worried about Tricki mainly because he has become:

A. aggressive B. listless and unhealthy C. disobedient D. injured

2. Mrs Pumphrey mistakenly thinks Tricki is suffering from:

A. fever B. malnutrition C. infection D. poisoning

3. Which food is mentioned as one of Tricki's rich extras?

A. Salad B. Cream cakes C. Bread only D. Rice

4. Tricki's main behavioural problem is described as:

A. laziness B. greed C. anger D. fear

5. Who is the narrator of the story?

A. Mrs Pumphrey B. Tricki C. James Herriot D. Hodgkin

6. Herriot advises Mrs Pumphrey to:

A. feed Tricki more B. give Tricki more sweets C. reduce food and increase exercise D. keep Tricki indoors

7. For the first two days at the surgery, Tricki receives:

A. rich food B. medicines only C. plenty of water but no food D. cream cakes

8. What helps Tricki become active again?

A. surgery B. interaction with other dogs C. chocolates D. Horlicks

9. Why does Herriot enjoy Tricki's stay?

A. Tricki pays him B. Mrs Pumphrey sends luxurious food and drinks C. Tricki guards the surgery D. He wants a new pet

10. Mrs Pumphrey calls the recovery:

A. a miracle of medicine B. a triumph of surgery C. a victory of science D. a lucky accident

11. Which quality best describes Herriot?

A. careless B. practical C. cruel D. impatient

12. The title is ironic because:

A. the dog was never ill B. no surgery was performed C. Mrs Pumphrey performed the operation D. Tricki performed surgery

13. Tricki becomes unhealthy mainly because of:  
A. cold weather B. overfeeding and lack of exercise C. old age D. an accident
14. Mrs Pumphrey's biggest weakness as a pet owner is:  
A. neglect B. excessive indulgence C. cruelty D. indifference
15. The story ultimately highlights the importance of:  
A. luxury B. discipline and balanced care C. expensive medicines D. surgery in every illness

### MCQ Answer Key

1-B, 2-B, 3-B, 4-B, 5-C, 6-C, 7-C, 8-B, 9-B, 10-B, 11-B, 12-B, 13-B, 14-B, 15-B

## 14. Teacher's Note on Answer Writing

For 2-3 marks: Answer directly, include the key event/reason and avoid unnecessary narration.

For 5-6 marks: Begin with a clear opening statement, develop 3-4 relevant points, and conclude with the central inference from the question.

For extract questions: Read the extract carefully, identify the speaker/context, and answer only what is asked.